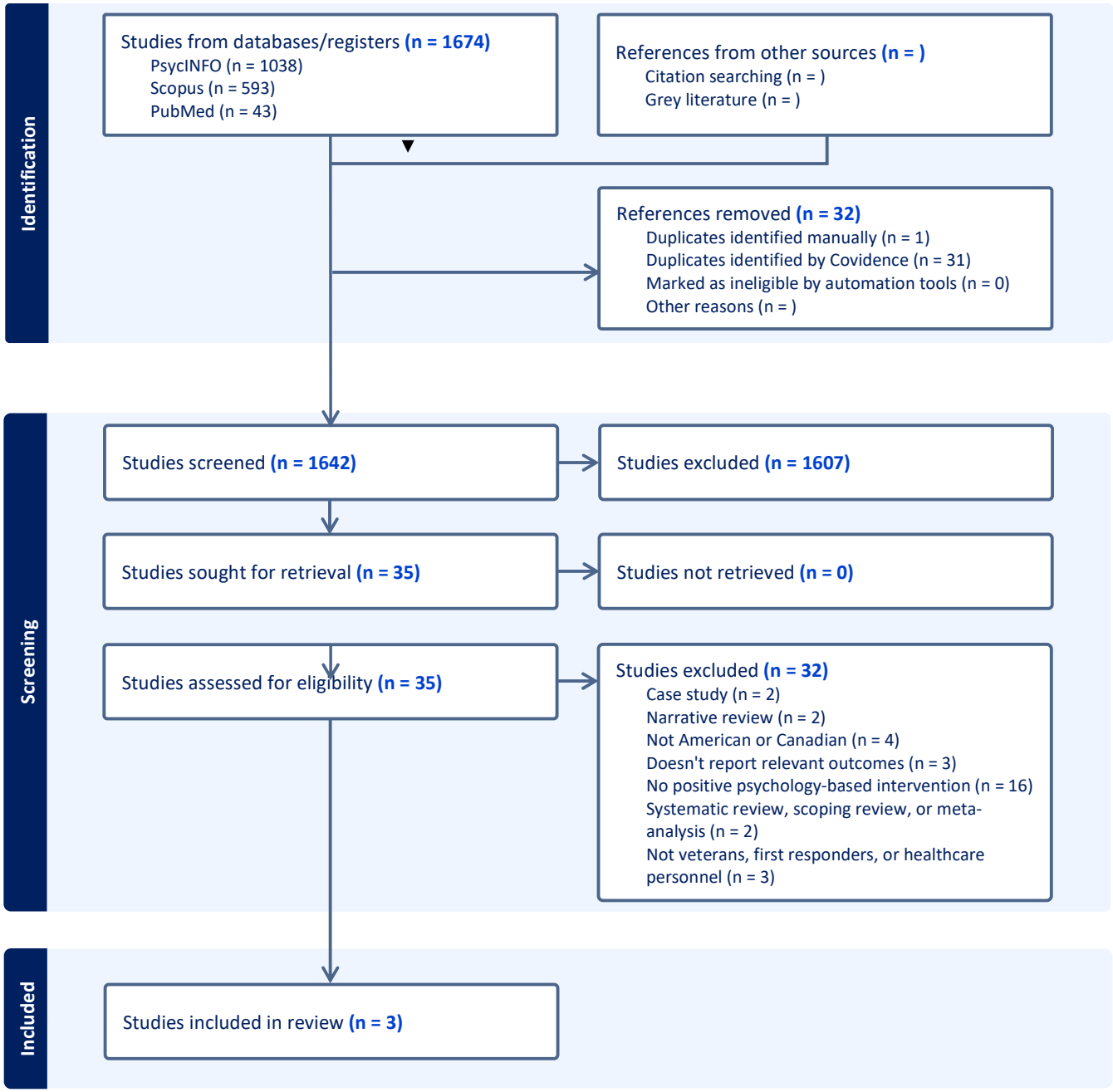
Effects of Positive Psychology–Based Interventions on PTSD and Moral Injury Symptoms: A Systematic Review

PRISMA Flow Diagram



Search Strategy

PsycInfo: 1,038 hits [02/20/2026]
DE (PTSD OR "posttraumatic stress disorder*" OR "post-traumatic stress disorder*"OR "posttraumatic stress"OR "post-traumatic stress") OR XB (PTSD OR "posttraumatic stress disorder*" OR "post-traumatic stress disorder*"OR "posttraumatic stress"OR "post-traumatic stress") OR DE (moral injur* OR "moral distress" OR "spiritual injur*" OR "ethical distress" OR "potentially morally injurious event*" OR PMIE*) OR XB (moral injur* OR "moral distress" OR "spiritual injur*" OR "ethical distress" OR "potentially morally injurious event*" OR PMIE*)
AND
DE ("positive psychology intervention*" OR "positive psychotherapy"OR "posttraumatic growth"OR "meaning-centered therap*"OR "strengths-based intervention*"OR "gratitude intervention*"OR "forgiveness intervention*"OR "well-being therap*") OR XB ("positive psychology intervention*" OR "positive psychotherapy"OR "posttraumatic growth"OR "meaning-centered therap*"OR "strengths-based intervention*"OR "gratitude intervention*"OR "forgiveness intervention*"OR "well-being therap*")

PubMed: 43 hits, [02/20/2026]
("Stress Disorders, Post-Traumatic"[Mesh] OR PTSD[tiab] OR posttraumatic stress disorder[tiab] OR post-traumatic stress disorder[tiab] OR posttraumatic stress[tiab] OR post-traumatic stress[tiab] OR moral injury[tiab] OR moral distress[tiab] OR spiritual injury[tiab] OR ethical distress[tiab] OR potentially morally injurious event[tiab] OR PMIE[tiab]) AND (positive psychology[tiab] OR positive psychology intervention[tiab] OR positive psychotherapy[tiab] OR posttraumatic growth[tiab] OR meaning-centered therapy[tiab] OR strengths-based intervention[tiab] OR gratitude intervention[tiab] OR forgiveness intervention[tiab] OR well-being therapy[tiab])

Scopus: 593 hits, [02/20/2026)
("PTSD" OR "post-traumatic stress disorder" OR "moral injury") AND ("positive psychology" OR "cognitive processing therapy" OR "prolonged exposure" OR "interpersonal therapy" OR "standard care") AND ("symptoms" OR "social functioning" OR "quality of life" OR "treatment outcome") AND ("veteran*" OR "first responder*" OR "healthcare personnel" OR "medical staff")

Inclusion / Exclusion Criteria

Population

Include

- Target Groups
  - Veterans
  - First responders
  - Healthcare personnel
- Specific Roles / Subgroups
  - Firefighters
  - Emergency medical services (EMS)
  - EMTs / paramedics
  - Police / law enforcement officers
  - Emergency department staff
- Demographics / Characteristics
  - Humans
  - Adults
  - Any gender
- Clinical / Psychological Criteria
  - Experiencing mental health impairments
  - Diagnosed Post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) or PTSD symptoms
  - Moral injury symptoms

Exclude

- Age / Sample Restrictions
  - Individuals under age 21
- Geographic Restrictions
  - Not from United States or Canada
- Clinical Exclusions
  - Individuals not experiencing mental health issues
- Sample Composition
  - Mixed samples with <50% belonging to target population
- Non-Target Populations
  - Animals

Intervention

Include

- General Definition
  - Psychological treatments integrating principles of positive psychology
  - Hybrid interventions if positive psychology components are a main component
- Core Positive Psychology Components
  - Meaning-making
  - Posttraumatic growth
  - Moral repair
  - Compassion
  - Forgiveness
  - Values clarification
  - Loving-kindness
  - Strength-based treatments
  - Acts of kindness
- Related Constructs / Approaches
  - Flourishing
  - Optimism
  - Character strengths

Exclude

- General Rule
  - Interventions not based on principles of positive psychology
- Trauma-Focused / Clinical Therapies
  - Cognitive Processing Therapy (CPT)
  - Adaptive Disclosure
  - Prolonged Exposure Therapy
- Cognitive / Behavioral Therapies
  - Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT)
  - Cognitive appraisal therapy
  - Behavioral therapy
- Other Psychotherapy Approaches
  - Eclectic psychotherapy
  - Psychodynamic therapy
  - Psychoanalytic therapy
  - Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT)
- Other Treatments
  - Eye Movement Desensitization and Reprocessing (EMDR)
  - Pharmacological treatments

Comparator

Include

- Standard care / treatment as usual (TAU)
- Waitlist control
- No-treatment control
- Active comparators (e.g., other psychotherapies like CBT, CPT, etc.)
- Attention control / placebo interventions

Exclude

Outcome

Include

- Reduction in PTSD symptoms
  - Measured using validated instruments (e.g., CAPS-5, PCL-5, or equivalent)
- Reduction in moral injury symptoms
  - Measured using validated instruments (e.g., MIES, MISS-M, or other validated moral injury measures)
- Secondary Outcomes
  - Posttraumatic growth (PTG)
  - Increased quality of life
    - (e.g., SF-36, WHOQOL-BREF, EQ-5D)
  - Increased social functioning

Exclude

- Studies that do not report any relevant outcome measures related to:
  - PTSD symptoms
  - Moral injury symptoms
  - Posttraumatic growth
  - Quality of life
  - Social functioning

Study Characteristics

Include

Exclude

- Cross-sectional
- Case study
- Narrative, systematic, or scoping review
- Meta-analysis
- Editorial, letter, commentary, or opinion piece